

Know Your English

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- Difference between ‘populous’ and ‘popular’

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- Both words come from the Latin ‘populus’ meaning ‘people’.
- When you say that someone is ‘**popular**’, what you are suggesting is that the **person is liked** or admired by many people. A restaurant that is ‘popular’ is frequented by many people; a lot of people eat there.
- ‘**Populous**’ is mostly used with a place — it could be a country, state, area, etc.
- When you say that a place is ‘populous’, what you are suggesting is that it is full of people; it is ‘**densely populated**’. India, for example, has a very big population — it is a populous country.
- These types of shoes are popular with teenagers.
- I don’t wish to live in a populous metropolitan city after I retire.
- *By the way, the word ‘pop’ in ‘pop music’ — the kind of music that a lot of people like to listen to — is actually a contraction of ‘popular’.*

- Who is an ‘history sheeter’?

Who is an 'history sheeter'?

- The terms are used to refer to a person with a criminal record — someone who has been arrested by the police.
- Native speakers of English refer to the sheet that the police use to list the crimes committed by an individual as 'rap sheet'. In India, it is called 'history sheet'.
- It contains the history of the crimes that the individual has committed or has been accused of committing. The term 'history sheeter' and 'rowdy history sheeter' were coined to refer to someone who has a criminal record — someone who has a 'history sheet.'
- Chances are, the well-known history sheeter, will be our next CM.
- The police refused to file an FIR against the rowdy history sheeter.

Piecemeal

Piecemeal

- Does it mean doing something little by little with no apparent plan?”
- “Exactly! Doing something little by little over a period of time in a rather unsystematic or random manner.
- Harini was upset because her recommendations had been implemented piecemeal.”
- “Over the years, the Government has provided piecemeal solutions to the water problem.”
- “That’s because our politicians can’t plan. They can only work piecemeal.

Showboating

Showboating

- The annoying way some players behave on the field just to attract the attention of the spectators and the television cameras.
- “I guess you could say that. The expression is mostly used in the **context of sports** to show disapproval.
- The thing I like about Federer and Nadal is that there's no showboating after they win a big event.

“Tell me, is there a difference between
‘despite’ and **‘in spite’**? ”

“Tell me, is there a difference between ‘**despite**’ and ‘**in spite**’? ”

- In terms of meaning, there is not much of a difference.
- You can use the two words interchangeably in most contexts.
- Just remember that ‘**in spite**’ is always followed by ‘**of**’ and ‘**despite**’ **is not**.
- The children continued to play **in spite of** the rain.
- The children continued to play **despite** the rain.

Grouch

- Hey, come on in! Good to see you. Happy New Year!”
“How can it be a happy one when I have assignments and tests hanging over my head? It’s just crazy how many....”
“Are you planning to be a **grouch** this year?”

A grouch is also a habitual complainer.

They tell me that Sandeep is the office grouch.”

Man Friday

- “Oh, Sandeep is doing fine. Getting used to his new job. Whenever he gets into trouble, his **Man Friday** helps him out.”
- “The expression is normally used to refer to your right hand man.”
- “Someone who does whatever you want him to, and who can be trusted.”
- “Exactly! Man Friday was the name that Robinson Crusoe gave the man he rescued from cannibals. This man became his trusted servant and later his friend.”

Erudite

Who is an **erudite** person?

It comes from the Latin ‘eruditus’ meaning ‘learned’ or ‘well informed’.

Nowadays, the word is used to mean ‘scholar’, someone who is very knowledgeable.

As expected, the professor’s talk was erudite.

Shilpa’s erudite friends talk about things that I have no interest in.

Washed up

Washed up



- When you refer to someone as being ‘washed up’, what you’re suggesting is that the person is no longer as successful as he once was.
- Directors don’t cast women who are in their 30s in lead roles because they believe they’re washed up.”
- Ever wondered why only women are washed up and not men (Film industry)
- “Our news channels provide opportunities to washed-up politicians to air their views.”



breakkkkkkkk

Topper

- In our country, a ‘topper’ is someone who gets the highest marks in a test/exam; a person who comes first in a competition is also referred to as a ‘topper’.
- *Chandrika says that she’s been a topper all her life.*
- *In the half-yearly exam, Bharat was the topper.*
- For a native speaker of English, however, ‘topper’ has a completely different meaning.
- It is sometimes used to refer to a person who is well liked by those around him.
- ‘Topper’ is also used to refer to a machine that ‘cuts off the top of weeds’.



Cacography



- It comes from the Greek ‘cacos’ meaning ‘bad’ or ‘ill’ and ‘graphy’ meaning ‘writing’.
- The word literally means bad writing or bad spelling.
- The teacher said that I lost marks because of my cacography.

Official and officious

- Noun - ‘official’ is someone who has the authority or the power to do something. People talk about ‘police official’, ‘government official’, and so on.
- adjective - ‘official spokesperson’ of a political party, you mean that he is the authorised or appointed individual.
- Used only as adjective - ‘officious’
- rather negative meaning.
- When you say that someone is ‘officious’, you mean that he is an official who asserts his authority very aggressively even in the case of trivial matters. This individual has an inflated opinion about his importance. **The word has another meaning as well someone who meddles in other people’s business can also be called ‘officious’.**
- *The **officious** clerk seldom looked at people and always sounded rude.*
- *What I like about Dilip’s parents is that they’re **seldom officious**.*

When are you leaving for Kolkata? When will you return?

- The word ‘back’ is unnecessary.
- I’ll be returning on Saturday.
- Or you could say, ‘I’ll be back on Saturday’.”

Cheesy

- Are IISER Mohali hostel rooms cheesy?
 - Politicians, the world over, have a cheesy smile.
- A cheesy hotel is a cheap hotel



Under the belt , below the belt

Under the belt

- You have the required experience in a particular area. You have put in the effort to learn the skills which might come in handy later.
- My father has 30 years of teaching experience **under his belt.**”

Although he has been playing in the IPL for the past two years, he doesn't have too many matches under his belt.”

Below the belt

“The expression comes from the world of boxing. During a bout, a boxer is not allowed to hit his opponent below the belt. All hits have to be above the waist.”

Our politicians aim below the belt all the time.



What is the meaning of ‘pittance’?



- not much; a meagre amount.
- You do not make enough to make ends meet. In your opinion, and perhaps in the opinion of others, you deserve to be paid a lot more.
- The scholarship I receive is just a pittance.
- Das needed cash; he ended up selling the house for a pittance.
- For the amount of work Geetha does, she's getting paid pittance.

Put your nose to the grindstone

- When you keep or put your nose to the grindstone, you work hard continuously, and that too for a long time. You persevere.
- Shweta put her nose to the grindstone all through high school in order to get into IISER.”



Saccharine

- Have you even come across a saccharine smile?
- excessively sweet or sentimental.
- Overtly sentimental
- Lacking in sincerity

A fake smile

Don't give me one of your saccharine smiles- just answer the question.



Favouritism, nepotism, cronyism

- All indicate preferential treatment to a person or group of people.

Favouritism – to a person not related to you

The teacher showed favouritism towards Meera.

Nepotism – from Latin ‘nepos’ meaning ‘nephew’

Favouritism based on kinship

If daddy/mummy is in politics, his darling daughter/son will own the constituency. (dynasty politics)

Cronyism picks up old childhood friends, somebody from the group, a close associate.

Usually used in business (crony capitalism)



Back-handed compliment

- Left-handed compliment
- Sujata told that I had a nice smile.

But when she asked who is my dentist I understood that it was a back/left handed compliment.

Leave in the lurch

- Parbhat left the exam hall after finishing the exam.
- Sargam felt that Parbhat left him in the lurch.
- (The previous night, they had decided to help out each other during the exam)
- Leave somebody in the difficult situation without offering help.
- Lurch – a sudden leaning of a ship to one side



Sidekick



- Dr Watson was Sherlock Holmes' sidekick.
- Someone who always spends his/her time with an important person.
- Why 'kick'
- One of the earlier meanings of the word 'kick' was 'walk'